

When you pull down, for example, the Misc menu, a small downward-pointing arrowhead appears at the bottom to let you know there are more items than can be displayed. Drag the pointer to this arrowhead and the menu will begin scrolling—moving the displayed menu items upward and revealing new items at the bottom. An up-arrowhead appears at the top of the menu; use it to scroll in the other direction and re-display the items that scrolled off the top.

Once you've found the item you want, selecting it works the same as if the menu didn't scroll. Just point to the item and release the mouse button.

Ellipsis...

Menu items followed by an ellipsis (three periods) always lead to a dialog. Dialogs are used to specify information the computer needs to complete your request. For example, if you choose to initialize a disk in the Finder, you'll need to tell the Finder the name for your new disk, as well as the format you want to use. A dialog appears to request this information when you select "Initialize" from the Disk menu. (We'll be talking about dialogs shortly.)

The Standard Menus

The first three menus on the menu bar are the same in nearly all Desktop programs. These are the  (Apple) menu, the File menu, and the Edit menu. (The rest of the menus will be tailored to each program's purpose.)

The  menu usually contains an "About" item which displays information about the program you're running (its name, its author, the version number, and so forth). In many cases the  menu also includes an option for on-screen help or other assistance. Below these menu items (if any), the  menu contains your New Desk Accessories (NDAs). NDAs are available from any Desktop programs and are like real-life desk accessories—calculators, note pads, etc. We'll be talking more about NDAs later.

The File menu contains options for creating, opening, saving, and closing documents (to work with a document, you open it first; when you're done, you close it). You'll also usually find a few other file-related options in the File menu, like "Print," as well as the program's Quit option.

The Edit menu contains items which allow you to change the information you've selected in some way. The "Cut," "Copy," and "Paste" options are used to transfer information from one document to another using a lllgs feature called the clipboard. The "Cut" option deletes the selected information from the document and places it on the clipboard. The "Copy" option leaves the information in your document but places a copy on the clipboard. The "Paste" option places the contents of the clipboard into the document you're working on. The clipboard can be used not only to exchange information between documents but also between programs.

The Edit menu usually also includes an "Undo" option, which reverses the effect of the last action you performed. (Often selecting "Undo" again after undoing an action will "re-do" that action). There's also usually a "Select All" option, for selecting everything in the document you're working on, and a "Clear" option, for deleting the current selection.